wrote another. “I ask whether it is really necessary to go to such extreme lengths of straining physical sensibilities (admitting that here I speak for myself) to resolve the logical difficulties of the quantum theory.”

But DeWitt remained convinced, and some of his readers were swayed as well. Everett’s interpretation had spent over a decade in deep obscurity. Now, “one of the best kept secrets of this century,” as DeWitt called it, was finally out.

DeWitt’s enthusiasm for the many-worlds interpretation was not merely driven by a desire to resolve the mysteries of quantum physics. Replying to his critics in *Physics Today*, DeWitt wrote that many-worlds “is the only conception that, within the framework of presently accepted [equations and mathematics], permits quantum theory to play a role at the very foundations of cosmology.” At the time DeWitt was writing, cosmology was more established as a research field than the foundations of quantum physics was—but that wasn’t saying very much. The idea that the universe as a whole was a suitable subject for scientific investigation was difficult for some physicists to swallow. General relativity, Einstein’s theory of gravity and warped spacetime that underpins cosmology, was a theoretical backwater, an accepted theory that was nonetheless considered to be useless. Einstein’s theory only differs appreciably from Newtonian gravity when dealing with extremely massive objects, objects at least as big as stars. But these massive objects that it dealt in were considered to be too far removed from everyday experience to be relevant to physics, and opinion was split over whether the theory’s implications for cosmology should be taken seriously at all. In 1962, a young physics student named Kip Thorne had just finished his undergraduate degree at Caltech and was about to go off to study general relativity at Princeton under John Wheeler. One of his Caltech professors attempted to dissuade him. “General relativity has little relevance for the real world,” Thorne recalled his professor telling him. “One should look elsewhere for interesting physics challenges.”

General relativity didn’t merely deal with abstruse situations—it was also written in abstruse mathematics. The theory is very mathematically